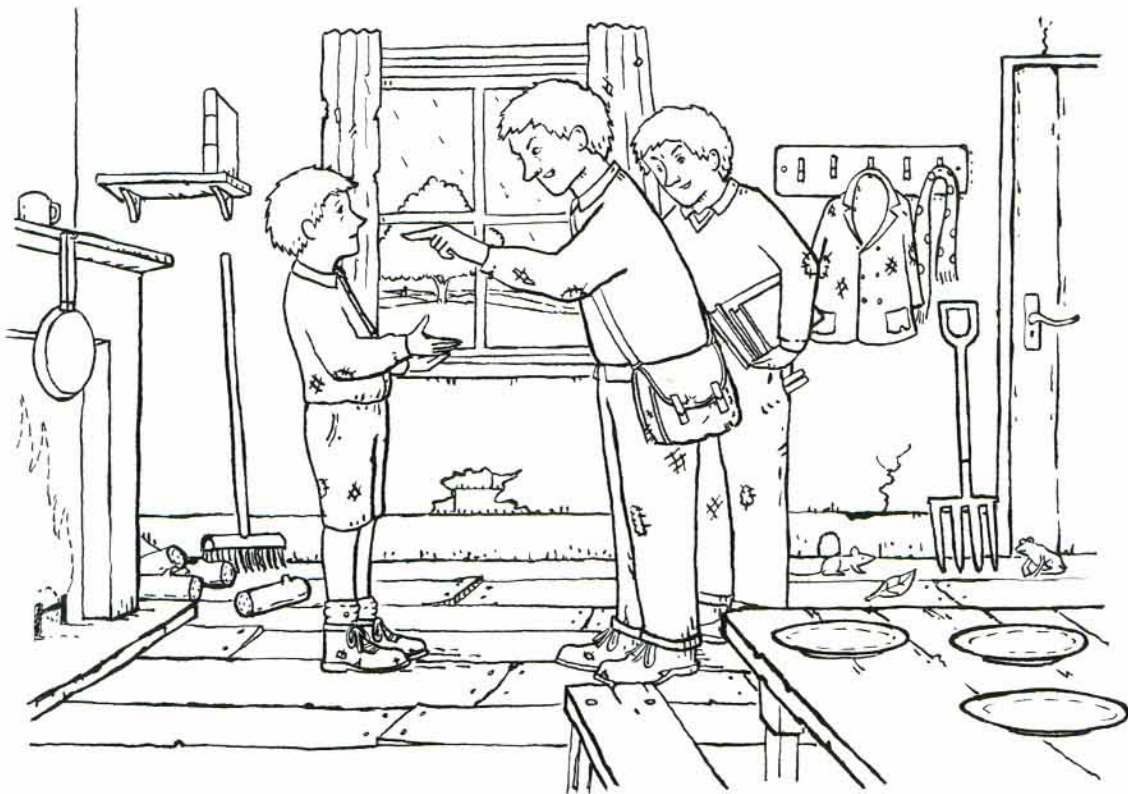




## Ben's wishes

I have an uncle who writes books for children. I didn't see my uncle very often when I was a child because he lived in Africa, but he came to see us sometimes. When he did visit us, he usually told me one of his stories. I loved them all but 'Ben's wishes' was my favourite. My uncle told it to me one winter when it was very cold outside. I was about ten, I think.



A boy called Ben had two older brothers. The older boys often felt hungry and often got angry because they were so poor.

'Go and work in the fields!' they said to Ben each morning. 'Dig up some vegetables! Make us some soup for dinner!'

Ben always answered in the same way. 'But I want to go to school and learn all about the world!' The brothers just laughed and said, 'Don't be silly! You aren't clever enough to go to school like us.'

So Ben didn't go anywhere. He just worked in the fields in the rain, digging and planting, and planting and digging.



Then he opened a small book that belonged to one of his brothers. Ben looked at the cup one more time and said, 'I'm lucky to have this book with me today, but I'd like 100 new books so I can learn all about the world, please.'

Suddenly, 100 new books fell from between the leaves in the tree above him. Ben couldn't believe it! He felt so lucky!



He laughed and laughed, put the old cup in his pocket, carried the books home, sat down by the fire and read them all.



When Ben's older brothers came home, they were really angry. 'Where's our dinner? Where's our vegetable soup?' they shouted.

Ben looked up and said, 'I found an old cup in the field today. I think it understands about wishes. It gave me hot chocolate, a warm coat and 100 new books to read. I've learned all about the world and all the animals that live in our world too. If you want your dinner, just ask the silver cup for it!'



The two older brothers looked at Ben's new coat, his new books and the silver cup on the table. One of them picked it up. He got very angry. 'We have a wish too! Give us our dinner! We want it this minute!' he said.

The empty bowls were suddenly full of vegetable soup. The brothers couldn't believe it!

'Cup!' the oldest brother shouted. 'Give me a room full of money.'

'Give me more money than my brother and a room full of sweets,' the other brother said.

Suddenly, there were sweets and money everywhere. The brothers began to fight.

'Give me that cup!' one shouted.

'No!' the other one said. 'It's mine. It's not yours. Give it to me!'



The cup fell on the ground and broke, and all the sweets, the money, the vegetable soup, Ben's warm coat and his 100 new books disappeared.

They were nowhere in the house.



I felt very sad when my uncle told me that part of the story. But then he added, 'But the cup couldn't make all the stories about the world disappear from Ben's head. And when Ben was a man, he visited all the countries in the world and wrote lots of stories about the animals and people who lived there to tell to children.'

I never knew my uncle's first name. I just called him Uncle.

Perhaps, just perhaps, it was Ben.